

OSHA Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) Requirements

Reference: 29 CFR 1910.132 - 1910.138

Overview

Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) is equipment worn to minimize exposure to hazards that cause serious workplace injuries and illnesses. OSHA Standard 29 CFR 1910.132 requires employers to conduct a hazard assessment and provide appropriate PPE at no cost to employees.

Head Protection (29 CFR 1910.135)

Hard hats must be worn where there is a potential for head injury from falling objects, bumps, or electrical hazards. Class E (Electrical) hard hats protect against up to 20,000 volts. Inspect hard hats daily for cracks, dents, and deterioration. Replace after any impact.

Eye and Face Protection (29 CFR 1910.133)

Safety glasses, goggles, or face shields must be worn when exposed to flying particles, molten metal, liquid chemicals, acids, caustic liquids, chemical gases, or intense light. All eye protection must meet ANSI Z87.1 standards. Side shields are required in areas with flying debris.

Hand Protection (29 CFR 1910.138)

Gloves must be selected based on the specific hazard: chemical-resistant gloves for corrosives, cut-resistant gloves for sharp edges, insulated gloves for electrical work, and heat-resistant gloves for high-temperature operations. Never use gloves near rotating machinery.

Foot Protection (29 CFR 1910.136)

Safety-toed footwear must be worn where there is danger of foot injury from hot substances, corrosive materials, or falling/rolling objects. ASTM F2413 compliant footwear with impact resistance of 75 ft-lb and compression resistance of 2500 lb is required.

Respiratory Protection (29 CFR 1910.134)

A written Respiratory Protection Program is required when engineering controls are not feasible. Medical evaluation, fit testing, and training are mandatory before respirator use. N95 filters remove 95% of airborne particles. Supplied-air respirators (SCBA) are required for IDLH atmospheres.

PPE Training Requirements

Employers must train each employee on: when PPE is necessary, what PPE is required, how to properly don/doff/adjust/wear PPE, limitations of PPE, and proper care/maintenance. Retraining is required when reason to believe the employee does not understand proper use.

